

THE SHAPE OF CONTROL

Spain's World Cup victory was the **culmination of an evolution**, where possession became the means rather than the end.

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The oldest footballing lesson in Spain has always been deceptively simple. If you have the ball, the opponent cannot score.

For years, however, that philosophy became both its greatest gift and its greatest burden. Spain monopolised possession, accumulated passes and controlled territory, but too often left tournaments wondering whether beautiful football alone could still win the biggest prizes. The echoes of tiki-taka lingered long after the golden generation had faded, sometimes becoming an identity that imprisoned rather than liberated.

At this World Cup, Spain did not abandon its football. It rediscovered its purpose.

Luis de la Fuente's world champions finished the tournament with the best defence, conceding only one goal in eight matches. They dominated possession as Spain always has, but possession was no longer the destination. It became the platform from which every other part of the game flourished. They pressed ferociously when they lost the ball, attacked vertically when spaces opened and defended with a discipline that suffocated some of the world's finest forwards.

By the time Rodri lifted the trophy in New Jersey after the 1-0 victory over Argentina, Spain had beaten Portugal, Belgium, France and the defending champion in successive knockout rounds. There could be little argument about the legitimacy of its crown.

The numbers only reinforced what the eye had already seen. France had arrived in the semifinal with the tournament's most feared attack. Kylian Mbappe,

Ousmane Dembele and Michael Olise had combined for 13 goals and 10 assists in their first six matches. Spain reduced them to shadows. Mbappe failed to register a shot on target. France managed only three efforts on target all evening and generated barely 0.15 expected goals (xG) from its celebrated front three. Spain's centre-backs Pau Cubarsi and Aymeric Laporte defended aggressively on the halfway line, while Rodri and Fabian Ruiz erased passing lanes before danger could develop.

Against Belgium in the quarterfinals, Spain patiently waited until Mikel Merino struck the decisive late winner. Against Portugal, it accepted a tactical battle and found the goal required to overcome the Iberian neighbour. In the final, it denied Lionel Messi the fairytale ending that seemed almost scripted.

Every challenge demanded something different, and Spain always had an answer.

That adaptability perhaps best explains why this team succeeded where previous Spanish sides had fallen. The Spain of Vicente del Bosque often appeared convinced that enough possession would eventually solve every problem. De la Fuente's Spain understood that football offers many different questions.

Sometimes the answer was Lamine Yamal. Still only a teenager,

MATCHES PLAYED

8

GOALS FOR

14

GOALS AGAINST

1

MOST GOALS

OYARZABAL – 5